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The structure of Kanuri society

Author(S): Cohen, Ronald

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 68

Culture (OWC): [Kanuri \(MS14\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1956-1957

Coverage Date: 1956-1957

Place Coverage: Magumeri, Borno State, Nigeria

Section Title(S): Joking Relationships (Suli)

Joking Relationships (suli)

Joking relationships (suli) among the Kanuri refer to a quality in interpersonal relations wherein the customary behavioural restrictions based on seniority, generation and sex differences are relaxed and a formalized pattern of permissiveness of some kind obtains between the parties.

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The most diffuse or broadly based joking relationship is that between ego and his grandparents and great-grandparents, if any of the latter are alive. In many cases Kanuri children are partially raised by their grandparents, being taken from their mother just after weaning. This is especially true when the child is called after his grandparent which is often the case since naming customs generally bring names from alternate generations down the descent system. The child usually has the most intimate and fondest joking relationship with his namesake grandparent, if this person lives close by or adopts him. When this is not the case, the grandparent residing closest is the person with whom a more intimate joking relationship is established. The naming rule gives no preference to matrilineal or patrilineal kinship; successive children must be named after and/or adopted by each of the spouse's parents alternatively. Thus neither side must obtain a namesake from the same marriage union twice in a row. The reason given for this custom of alternation is that it helps to prevent conflict and jealousy between a man and his wife as well as

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between the married couple and 69 their respective kindred and in-laws. There is no rule about which group should take precedence although the comparative social status of the patrilineal and matrilineal kin seems to be a major factor in the decision. Informants claimed that the child must be taken away from his grandparents some time before puberty and brought under the direct control of his parents so that he (or she) may learn proper respect (berzum) because there is no berzum, they said, when there is much suli. Table I indicates that this latter judgment is only an approximation to the overall pattern since 14.9% of all responses by ego to grandparents indicate the presence of some respect (berzum) behaviour. As a general rule the reciprocity of the joking relationships between alternate generations of the kinship system, extending to include the third ascendant and descendant generations (the yeiya), follows a pattern of more respect between ego and his grandparents and more friendship and fondness between ego and his grandchildren.

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